



ELIPHAS LEVI (1810–75)

## French occultist extraordinaire

Eliphas Lévi's real name was Alphonse Constant, and he had trained, though never qualified, as a Catholic priest. He became a socialist and, inspired by Mesmer, an enthusiast for magic. Lévi argued for a universal order based on Catholicism, socialism, and magic. His book *Transcendental Magic: Its Doctrine and Ritual* described and illustrated the Baphomet (see left), an idol first chronicled by the medieval Crusaders. Lévi called the creature his "Sabbatic goat," and claimed that it held all knowledge. With its many magical meanings, it represents male and female, good and evil, fertility and life. Lévi's work is still studied by magicians today.

**Baphomet** was a monster with a goat's head, woman's body, wings, a pentagram on its forehead, and alchemical quotations on its arms.

### ▼ Evening of magnetism

This publicity sheet offers a demonstration of magnetism in Switzerland in May 1857 by one E. Allix, "Professeur de Magnétisme." Many showmen of dubious qualifications jumped on Mesmer's bandwagon.

### The power of sleep

Mesmer was effectively branded a charlatan, and he died in exile in Switzerland in 1815. However, his legacy remained and mesmerism itself continued to be practiced well into the 19th century. Among its most influential proponents was the Marquis de Puységur. He was an avid disciple of Mesmer, but from the 1780s he pioneered a new form of hypnotic induction that he termed "artificial somnambulism," somnambulism meaning sleepwalking. Not only was the subject unaware of his or her condition, but, susceptible to hypnotic suggestion, they would later perform any act that the mesmerist had put to them.

### Subconscious revealed

The realization that human beings have a powerful subconscious as well as conscious mind had huge implications for the development of psychology, and for the occult and the supernatural. It also paved the way for the emergence of the medium (the middle person communicating between the spirit and material worlds).

In 1841, James Braid, a Scottish doctor and pillar of the Scottish medical establishment, became a sudden convert to the potential of mesmerism as a legitimate medical tool after watching a performance by a French mesmerist, Charles Lafontaine. What struck him were not the theatrical antics of Lafontaine but the fact that

the subjects had so evidently been reduced to a trance, unable even to open their eyes. On further investigation, he demonstrated both the physical reality of this altered consciousness and its valuable medical application, not least as an anesthetic, as the subject was impervious to pain. Braid coined the new term "hypnosis," after Hypnos, the Greek god of sleep.

### Into the occult

Braid and other hypnotists, notably two Frenchmen, Jean-Martin Charcot—one of whose pupils was Sigmund Freud, the founder of psychoanalysis—and Hippolyte Bernheim, carried on their development of Mesmer's work. While they made clear the possibilities of hypnotism as a tool in the scientific study of the human mind, its appeal to the occult was equally apparent, as documented by French ceremonial magician and author Eliphas Lévi (see above).



"It is ... extremely dangerous to make sport of the Mysteries of Magic."

ELIPHAS LEVI, *TRANSCENDENTAL MAGIC: ITS DOCTRINE AND RITUAL*, 1854–1856